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HERMES Mail/X: A continuation of Eudora in Cocoa for the Mac



An eMail client built for power users from the ground up, written in 100% Cocoa and inspired by HERMES Mail and Eudora for Windows.

Created by

Nicholas Edward Werner-Matavka

28 backers pledged CA\$ 1,669 to help bring this project to life.

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pledged of CA\$ 1,250 goal

28

backers

Funding period

Dec 19 2018 - Feb 17 2019 (60 days)

Story

History

In 1988, Steve Dorner wrote an eMail client for the Macintosh that soon grew to have an army of very satisfied users. It was named "Eudora" in honour of American authoress Eudora Welty, who wrote a short story called "Why I Live at the P.O." Eudora quickly gained a legion of fans and was bought out by Qualcomm in 1991. Soon after that, it was re-written ("ported", in computerese) for PC's as well. Fast forward to 2006 and, amidst shifting corporate priorities, Qualcomm Eudora was killed off, to be replaced by a pale imitation called Eudora OSE. This was not well received and soon died as well.

Eudora still has its fans, though, which is why we're bringing it back! This year, its code was open-sourced and given to the Computer History Museum. Seeing that nobody had taken on the monumental task of reviving this excellent piece of software and updating it to comply with today's standards, I picked up development myself, along with a talented team of C++ programmers.

Legal encumbrances prevented us from using the Eudora name, so the program was re-christened Hermes, after the Greek personification of business and patron deity of messengers. We plan to release the Windows version in Q1 2019.

Macintosh

During our previous Kickstarter campaign, we were bombarded with requests to resurrect Eudora for Apple Mac as well. We thought long and hard about how to do this. Our original plan was to rewrite the user interface of the Windows version in order to make it compatible with almost all platforms and technologies (including OS X, other flavours of

UNIX, Android)... unfortunately, it didn't quite work out that way. If we coded the interface that way, much of Eudora's "sexiness" would be gone.

We are debating two alternatives; the choice between them is dependent on the fact that Eudora was actually **two programs**, written in different languages (C and C++) on separate platforms (x86 and Power PC, in those days) by parallel teams of developers. One idea is to abandon Macintosh Eudora and to write a Macintosh interface from scratch, with the code as a whole coming from the Windows version. The benefits of this approach are that it's economical in respect to time (given that the Windows code is more complete and up-to-date) and cost (given that only one development team need exist). The drawback is that people who have grown up on Macintosh Eudora might be unused to the Windows version running on their computer.

The other idea is to open a separate project, with the code coming from the Macintosh version. This has the benefit of being more specific to OS X as well as UNIX, but besides duplicating time, energy, and cost, the Macintosh code is less complete, obsolescent (it's written in Carbon rather than Cocoa), and uses obsolete tools (like the CodeWarrior integrated development environment).

As work proceeds, we will know better which is the right approach to follow. We are currently pursuing both; it may be that we won't know until shortly before launch which version will receive official support, and which will receive community support. In the world of software development, such an occurrence is not unheard of. More likely, though, **we will know very early on that one of the alternatives is impossible. Then, we can focus all our resources on developing the other.**

Promises

When we first announced our intention to continue developing the eMail client formerly known as QUALCOMM Eudora, we could not begin to imagine the specific challenges ahead of us, but we had a good idea, in a broad-brush and somewhat academic way, of The Things We Had To Do—even before our mail client had a name. We understood:

- that the way the "new Eudora" displayed rich-text messages had to change;
- that Eudora's interface was dependent on a toolkit that was not only prohibitively expensive but also outdated;
- that we'd need to support Eudora 7 until we'd released its successor; and
- that writing the "new Eudora" for Macintosh would be Hard Work.

We made certain commitments to our Windows backers and our users, and we kept them—for the most part. Right now, we are using this space

to make similar, specific commitments vis-a-vis Macintosh. We promise you, our Macintosh backers and users, that:

- HERMES Mail/X will support Unicode (UTF-8) and the ability to send messages in every left-to-right alphabetic language (we'll try to support right-to-left languages and those that aren't alphabetic as well)
- HERMES Mail/X will include a spelling checker or support the spelling checker included in OS X
- in general terms, *there will be a successor to Eudora that will run on all computers with OS X (32-bit and 64-bit)*
- between the release of HERMES Mail and Mail/X, there will be a stopgap measure, such that you will be able to run the successor to Eudora on your Mac.

Our Progress So Far

Although it's manifestly unsuitable for general release, HERMES Mail for Windows now sends and receives messages. Another variant of HERMES Mail does not have message-sending capability, but the interface has been built from the ground up. The HERMES SSL Extensions are in wide use and (when installed correctly) work correctly. On the other hand, some of the details we published were wrong or impossible, and one might summarise our work as "promises made—promises broken"... but that would be wilful distortion of the truth. The big picture has been painted true to the original description, and we simply need to fill in the details in a different manner than originally intended.

We've been mostly silent about HERMES Mail/X (for reasons which will soon become apparent). We now aim to correct this oversight, especially given the number of people asking for their preferred platform to be supported. Given that OS X is essentially a variant of UNIX, we've hit upon a unique solution: as soon as HERMES Mail/Win is released, those who need Mac OS X (and UNIX workstation) support Right The Freak Now will merely need to install it and the Wine compatibility layer. That's not a **complete** solution, though; we promised to offer a mail client **for the Mac (and UNIX workstation)**, not for simulated Windows (and all that implies).

Once again, though, there's no such thing as a free lunch. The previous campaign raised sufficient money to create a quality product, but putting that product into the hands of as many people as possible is a challenge (largely due to media intransigence), and creating a *whole new product* opens up a whole new can of worms, due to the many transitions that the Apple architecture has undertaken since 2005 (certainly more than the PC, which has remained largely stable since that date with the exception of the x64 chipset).

Risks and challenges

The biggest hurdle, this time around, is manpower. The Mac has lower market share than the PC, which is as true now as it was in 1997, but the implications of that fact now and then are different. In the 1990s, the Macintosh simply was not technically stable, meaning that its major users were in education (and thus its "friendliness" was paramount).

Programmers for it, therefore, were harder to find. To-day, the Macintosh has become entirely divorced from that heritage and instead is UNIX with graphics tweaks. While programmers for UNIX have always been and still are easy to find, they have always been and still are more expensive to employ.

Beyond this lies the issue of the code itself. Because Eudora was written on 1990's Macs, then ported to 2000's UNIX/Mac hybrids, and now stands to be ported again to 2010's pure UNIX, there has been and will be far more upheaval in the source than there was with the Windows version.

The original code was written for CodeWarrior, a product no longer supported by its manufacturer; Carbon is outdated and must be transitioned to Cocoa; and so on, and so forth.

In general, we will need to employ more programmers this time around, and they will come at a more expensive price. Still, we will create the product—and finally, Apple users will no longer be subjected to the tortures of Apple Mail.

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